T.O Analytics LLC

2026–2027 COHORT

SPLUNK ORIENTATION

Zero to Hero

Saturday, October 31, 2026
8:00–10:00 AM Eastern

Today’s orientation

The learning path

Complete Power User and Admin certification goals before formal classes.

Your personal lab

Purchase a server and prepare to build eight virtual machines in Proxmox VE.

The Saturday curriculum

Ten sessions from January 9 through March 13, 2027, starting at 8:00 AM Eastern.

Your next actions

Set your study plan, confirm hardware, and begin weekly instructor check-ins.

The program has two phases

NOW THROUGH DECEMBER 2026

Prepare for Power User first, then Enterprise Admin.

Use the exam blueprints, study resources, and short practice exercises.

Contact the instructor every week with questions and progress.

JANUARY–MARCH 2027

Build and operate your own distributed Splunk lab.

Apply the concepts from certification study in weekly hands-on work.

Finish with a working deployment, dashboards, and a troubleshooting demo.

Dates everyone needs

Milestone	Date	Expected result
Orientation	Oct 31, 2026	Know the plan and requirements
Power User deadline	Nov 28, 2026	Pass Splunk Core Certified Power User
Admin deadline	Dec 19, 2026	Pass Splunk Enterprise Certified Admin
First official class	Jan 9, 2027	Proxmox installation and VM setup
Final class / capstone	Mar 13, 2027	Demonstrate the complete lab

All official classes: Saturdays at 8:00 AM Eastern.

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Certification comes first

01 CORE CERTIFIED POWER USER

Deadline: Saturday, November 28, 2026

No prerequisite certification. Focus on SPL, fields, knowledge objects, and data models.

Use official objectives to identify gaps and explain why each answer is correct.

02 ENTERPRISE CERTIFIED ADMIN

Deadline: Saturday, December 19, 2026

Power User is the prerequisite. Focus on system administration and data administration.

Schedule early enough to leave room for a retake under current exam policies.

Weekly preparation and support

Every week through December

Reach out to the instructor with exam questions, difficult topics, and your progress.

Power User study period

From orientation through November 28: practice SPL and review the official blueprint.

Admin study period

After Power User through December 19: work through configuration and ingest scenarios.

Free T.O Analytics practice questions

Instructor reports a 100% first-attempt pass rate among more than 14 past users. Results vary.

Study hub: www.to-analytics.com

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A server is required for every student

Required purchase

Every student must purchase a dedicated server for their personal virtualization lab.

Recommended option

Use the instructor’s Amazon link below. Verify the selected RAM and storage configuration.

Proposed lab target

x86-64 CPU with VT-x / AMD-V, 8+ cores, 64 GB RAM, 1 TB SSD/NVMe, wired Ethernet.

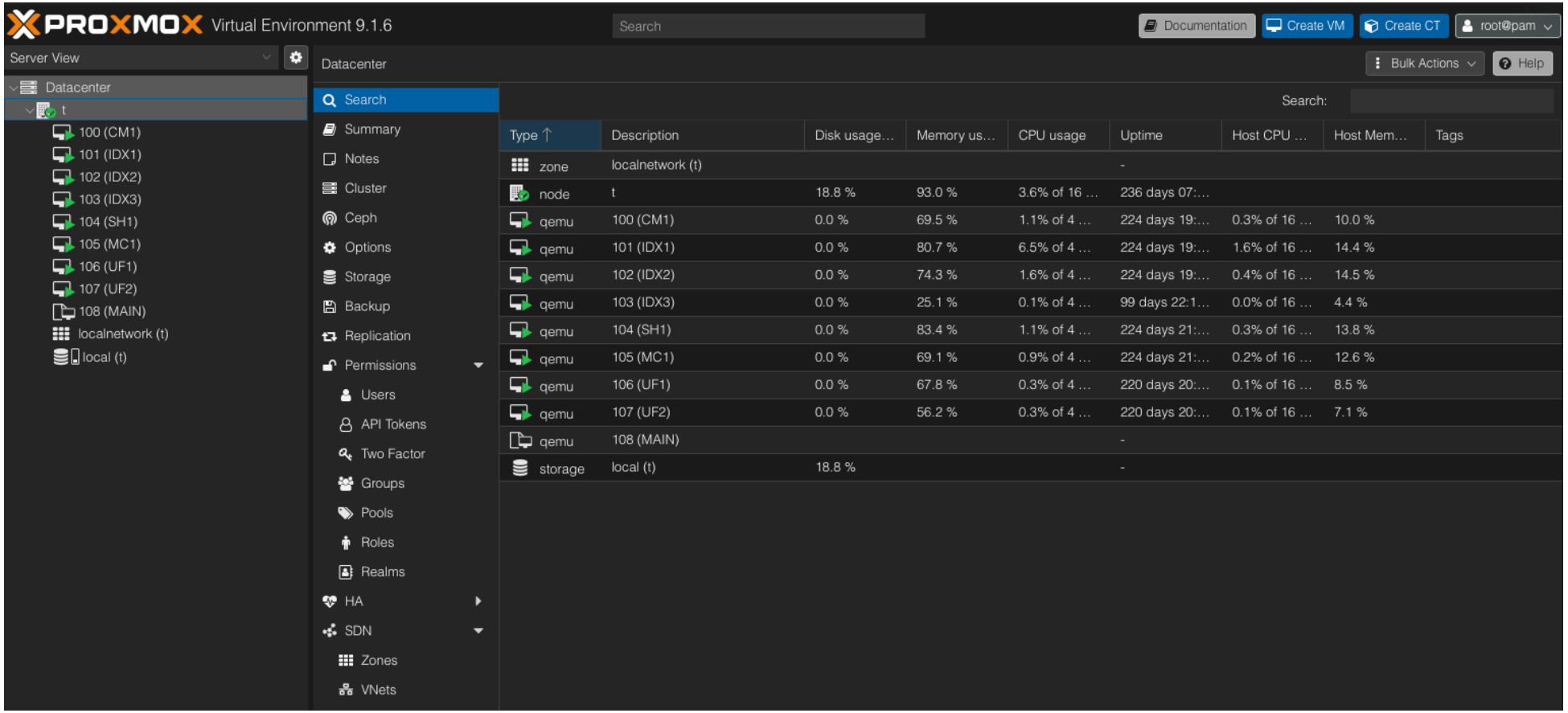
Before January 9

Have the server, a separate laptop, bootable USB media, and a working network ready.

Recommended server: https://a.co/d/0dqtgNco

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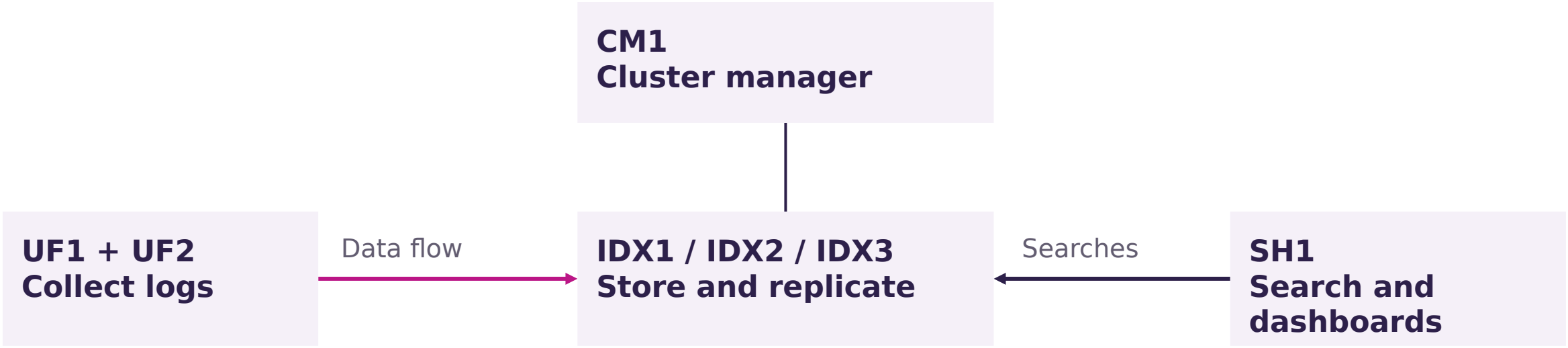
Your Proxmox lab will look like this



Eight Splunk VMs on one physical host. “MAIN” is optional.

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Eight virtual machines, distinct roles



MC1: deployment server, license manager, monitoring console

Lab cluster: replication factor 2, search factor 2. One host still means one physical failure domain.

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A starting resource budget

VM role	Count	vCPU / VM	RAM / VM	Disk / VM
CM1	1	2	4 GB	40 GB
IDX1–IDX3	3	4	8 GB	120 GB
SH1	1	4	8 GB	60 GB
MC1 (DS / LM / MC)	1	2	6 GB	60 GB
UF1–UF2	2	1	2 GB	20 GB
Guest allocation	8	22 total	46 GB total	560 GB total

64 GB host RAM leaves room for Proxmox and overhead. vCPU totals assume light lab use.

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Licensing needs an early plan

The Enterprise trial lasts 60 days

The standard trial allows 500 MB/day. January 9–March 13 spans 63 days.

A license must cover the entire cluster lab

Arrange an authorized training or other eligible license before the lab begins.

Developer licenses have a specific purpose

The 10 GB/day developer program is for eligible app development and requires approval.

Splunk Free is not the cluster fallback

Its standalone scope does not replace the Enterprise features required by this curriculum.

Request Dev License - https://dev.splunk.com/developer-program/

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Before the first official class

Accounts and access

Create your Splunk account. Confirm download access, course resources, and license eligibility.

Hardware and network

Confirm capacity, wired connectivity, virtualization support, and a private IP plan.

Safe installation preparation

Back up the server’s existing data. Proxmox installation can erase the selected disk.

Downloads and documentation

Prepare Proxmox media and an instructor-approved Linux ISO. Keep an IP and hostname inventory.

The ten-Saturday curriculum

Date	Session	Lab outcome
Jan 9	Proxmox and virtual machines	Eight Linux VMs, networking, snapshot
Jan 16	Distributed Splunk architecture	Installed roles and working cluster
Jan 23	Forwarders and data onboarding	Validated os, network, gamelog inputs
Jan 30	SPL and field knowledge	Reusable searches and extractions
Feb 6	Dashboard Studio and reports	Three dashboards with drilldowns

The ten-Saturday curriculum, continued

Date	Session	Lab outcome
Feb 13	Alerts, CIM and security use cases	Scheduled detections and CIM mapping
Feb 20	Administration and automation	RBAC, configuration apps, REST exercise
Feb 27	Health, performance and recovery	Failure drill and troubleshooting runbook
Mar 6	Modern Splunk capabilities	SPL exercise and feature demonstrations
Mar 13	Capstone demonstration	Working deployment and final handoff

January 9: Proxmox and Linux foundations

Build the virtualization host

Install Proxmox VE, configure storage and a network bridge, and confirm management access.

Create the eight Linux VMs

Use templates or clones, unique hostnames, private addresses, DNS/hosts resolution, and time sync.

Establish a safe baseline

Configure SSH access, updates, a dedicated Splunk service account, and a recovery snapshot.

Evidence to submit

VM inventory, IP map, successful SSH tests, and a documented restore procedure.

January 16: The Splunk architecture build

Install and assign roles

Install Enterprise on CM1, IDX1–IDX3, SH1 and MC1. Install Universal Forwarder on UF1 and UF2.

Configure the cluster

Set RF=2 and SF=2, connect SH1, and deploy os, network and gamelog as replicated indexes.

Connect management and forwarding

Configure MC1 licensing, deployment services and monitoring. Forward internal logs centrally.

Evidence to submit

Healthy cluster, searchable test events, forwarder connectivity, and Monitoring Console visibility.

January 23: Data onboarding that scales

Deploy inputs through apps

Use server classes and UF configuration apps. Understand where parsing and search-time settings belong.

Work with the lab data

Onboard Linux logs, web access logs, Cisco web/mail logs, and the game XML dataset.

Validate before production-style routing

Check event boundaries, timestamps, time zones, host, source and sourcetype in a test index first.

Evidence to submit

An input inventory and validation searches for os, network and gamelog. Add an HEC exercise.

January 30: SPL and knowledge objects

Search efficiently

Use search, where, eval, stats, eventstats, timechart and time functions with explicit time ranges.

Extract and enrich fields

Practice rex and spath, then create reusable extractions, lookups, aliases and calculated fields.

Reuse and correlate

Build macros, tags and event types. Compare stats-based correlation with transaction and join.

Evidence to submit

A tested search workbook with expected results, field definitions and correct object permissions.

February 6: Reports and Dashboard Studio

Build the required dashboards

Create OS, Network and Game Activity views based on the deployment lab reporting requirements.

Make the dashboard interactive

Use inputs, tokens, drilldowns, base/chain searches, and clear empty-result behavior.

Apply current Studio features

Explore treemap, table interactions and JSON inspection where the selected lab version supports them.

Evidence to submit

Three shared dashboards with tested panels and reusable report searches.

February 13: Alerts and security analytics

Turn a useful search into an alert

Set schedules, time windows, thresholds and throttling. Test actions using controlled sample events.

Map data to CIM

Validate field names and tags. Compare raw searches with data models and accelerated tstats.

Introduce detection engineering

Write a failed-login use case, explain false positives, and connect it to a relevant ATT&CK technique.

Evidence to submit

A tested alert, a CIM mapping checklist, and a short detection explanation.

February 20: Administration and automation

Manage access and ownership

Configure roles and index access. Test knowledge-object sharing and service-account ownership.

Control configuration changes

Understand precedence, local/default, app packaging, btool, server classes and cluster bundles.

Automate repeatable tasks

Use a read-only REST inventory exercise, simple scripts, and Git for configuration history.

Evidence to submit

A least-privilege role, versioned configuration app, inventory output, and rollback instructions.

February 27: Troubleshooting and recovery

Measure environment health

Use Monitoring Console, _internal and _audit to inspect ingest delays, queues and scheduled searches.

Improve performance

Review expensive SPL, job inspection, acceleration, retention, bucket sizing and storage pressure.

Test availability and recovery

Stop one indexer in a controlled exercise, verify searches, restore service and check cluster recovery.

Evidence to submit

A failure-drill report and a runbook covering diagnosis, recovery and verification.

March 6: Modern Splunk in practice

SPL2 alongside SPL

Explore datasets, modules and SQL-style syntax. Compare the result of a simple SPL2 search with SPL.

AI-assisted search

Review generated searches for correctness, permissions, time range and performance before running them.

Data pipelines and observability

Demonstrate Edge Processor concepts and OpenTelemetry logs, metrics and traces when access permits.

Evidence to submit

One SPL2 example plus a short explanation of Enterprise, Cloud, security and observability boundaries.

March 13: Capstone and final review

Demonstrate your deployment

Explain every VM role and show healthy replication, searchable data and monitoring.

Demonstrate the user experience

Present OS, Network and Game Activity dashboards plus a tested scheduled alert.

Resolve a troubleshooting scenario

Explain the symptom, gather evidence, apply a fix and verify the result.

Deliver your portfolio

Submit the architecture diagram, sanitized configuration apps, searches and operating runbook.

The capstone acceptance checklist

Deployment and availability

Eight roles are reachable. RF/SF are met. Search remains usable during a one-indexer failure drill.

Data quality and analytics

The three indexes have valid events. OS, Network and Game Activity dashboards answer the lab questions.

Operations and security

Monitoring works, a scheduled alert fires, permissions are tested, and secrets stay out of exports.

Repeatability and explanation

Another engineer can follow your inventory, configuration notes and recovery runbook.

Tuition and course expectations

$3,500

Course tuition

Zelle
t.oanalyticsllc@gmail.com

Every student purchases a server.

Attend Saturday sessions and complete weekly labs.

Bring questions and share progress during the certification phase.

Confirm exam fees and any other costs with the instructor.

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Your next steps

This week

Set your Power User study schedule and contact the instructor with your first questions.

By November 28

Pass Power User, then complete Admin preparation for the December 19 deadline.

Before January 9

Purchase your server, verify capacity and connectivity, and confirm the lab licensing plan.

January 9 at 8:00 AM Eastern

Join ready to install Proxmox and build the virtual machines for your Splunk environment.

Resources and reference material

T.O Analytics study hub

Power User certification and blueprint

Enterprise Admin certification and blueprint

Splunk Enterprise release notes

What is new in Dashboard Studio

Proxmox VE requirements

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